



Long wait: The Italian team's last win on home soil came in 2019 when Charles Leclerc took his second career victory. It was the year when the Ferrari engine was the class of the field. REUTERS

managed to get ahead of Leclerc by pitting earlier. The stage was set for a comfortable 1-2 for McLaren. Norris, though, made many uncharacteristic mistakes and struggled with graining on his front left tyres. He came in early for a second stop, and Piastri, too, hit similar trouble, though not to the same extent as Norris.

It was at this point that McLaren lost the plot when it took the cautious approach to stop Piastri on lap 38, giving up the lead to Leclerc. Ferrari, though, decided to brave it out on a one-stopper.

Ultimately, it was a straight fight between Piastri and Leclerc, in which the latter managed to hold on to his lead and win it by seconds, showing excellent tyre management skills to take his second win of 2024.

On a day when Max Verstappen struggled in his Red Bull, finishing only sixth, Norris had a chance to make a significant dent in the former's lead.

McLaren may have missed an opportunity by not imposing team orders at the start or even toward the end. Swapping places would have helped Norris gain three more points on the reigning champion.

Norris now trails Verstappen by 62 points and could have reduced the lead by ten more had things gone slightly differently.

McLaren will hope the points lost here don't come back to bite it at the end of the year. In the constructors' standings, McLaren only trails Red Bull by eight points, and if the form book continues, it is on course to win the title it last won in 1998.

MotoGP

Return of the King

When Marc Marquez (**below**) won in Misano in 2021, no one would have expected the six-time MotoGP champion not to win a race for the next three years. It has been a trying few years for the Spaniard as he dealt with injuries and uncompetitive Honda machinery. By the end of last year, he'd had enough of Honda and switched to Gresini Racing to ride a year-old Ducati bike for 2024. His decision proved correct when he won his first race after 1,043 days by winning the Aragon Grand Prix. He made it doubly special on home soil by doing the double, as he had also clinched the Sprint race on Saturday. The 31-year-old took pole position and cruised to victory ahead of Jorge Martin. Reigning champion Francesco Bagnaia, though, had a miserable weekend, crashing out of the race



after colliding with Marc's teammate and brother, Alex Marquez, while fighting for third. A week later, Marquez showed he was well and truly back, winning the San Marino GP at Misano, beating Bagnaia in the factory Ducati.

The non-points finish followed a disappointing showing in the Sprint, where Bagnaia finished ninth. This allowed Martin, who had a pair of second-place finishes, to take a 23-point lead.

In Misano, Marquez beat Bagnaia in a straight fight in mixed weather conditions to climb up to third in the riders' standings. With this win, the Spaniard sent a strong message to the two-time champion Bagnaia, who will be his teammate next year in the works Ducati team.

However, Martin's huge blunder on Sunday was the big talking point in the race. When a brief spell of rain hit the track during the race, the championship leader pitted to change bikes with wet tyres. Unfortunately, the rain abated soon after. This meant the Prima Pramac rider on the satellite Ducati had to swap bikes again and settle for 15th place, taking home a solitary point. The gamble proved costly, and his healthy lead shrunk to seven points.